



Down East Decoy Carving



Would these trick you if you were a duck?

Did you know? People in coastal North Carolina carve ducks from wood—not for toys, but to tell stories, hunt, and honor traditions!

What Is a Decoy?

A duck decoy is a wooden model of a duck used to attract real ducks. In the past, hunters in Carteret County carved them by hand. Today, decoys are also artwork and symbols of Down East traditions.

Carving the Tradition

For generations, carvers in Down East towns like Harkers Island have turned blocks of wood into lifelike ducks. This skill is passed down through families and shared at festivals like the Core Sound Decoy Festival.



- Typical Tools:** knives, rasps, brushes
- Materials:** cedar or tupelo wood, paint
- Ducks Carved:** mallard, pintail, redhead, bufflehead
- Notable Carvers:**

Homer Fulcher, Brother Gaskill, Jason Michels



Scan the code to check out a “Tutorial of Decoy Carving” by Jason Michels and Clay Michels:



Mallards are the most common and recognizable ducks in North America. These birds can grow between 18 and 28 inches long, with wings that stretch 30 to 40 inches wide. When flying, mallards are fast—they can travel up to 55 miles per hour and often migrate in a “V” formation, covering as much as 1,500 miles at a time! Mallards are called “dabblers” because they tip forward in the water to feed rather than diving. Like most waterfowl, they have special features that help them live in wet places: broad, flat bills to filter food, waterproof feathers to stay dry, and webbed feet to swim smoothly through ponds and marshes.

How to Make A Decoy?

1

Trace the Shape on Wooden Blocks



Using a pencil or stencil, the carvers use templates passed down through generations, while some other sketch freehand based on duck photos or field guides. This step is all about planning: Where will the tail go? What pose will the head be in?

2

Carve Out the Basic Shape



Cut out the rough shape using saws or carving knives. Remove large chunks of wood first to create a rounded body, then begin refining the curves of belly, back, and tail. Common tools include bandsaws, drawknives, and gouges.

3

Sand the Body and Head Smooth



Carefully smoothen and refine the body and head using rasps, files, or sandpapers. This step helps the wood feel soft and makes the duck look more lifelike. Carvers might add special lines or ridges to suggest feathers or wing curves.

4

Attach the Head to the Body



In traditional carving, the head and body are carved separately, then carefully joined together. Carvers use wood glue and dowels or screws to attach the head securely. It must be placed at just the right angle. The head gives each decoy its unique personality,

5

Paint the Decoy



Finally, it’s time to bring the duck to life with color! Carvers use paint to show feathers, eyes, and markings that match real duck species like redheads, mallards, and buffleheads. Each brushstroke matters—especially around the wing tips.

Fun Facts about Decoy

- Did you know that not all decoys are meant to float?
- Every duck decoy is one of a kind—just like real ducks! Although carvers use the same shape, each one adds their own details and painting style.
- Every year in Carteret County, people gather to show off their carving skills at the Core Sound Decoy Festival.

Why Do People Carve?

Why do people carve ducks instead of just watching real ones? The answer is all about Connection. Carving helps people observe ducks more closely, understand how they live, and honor local traditions. When you carve a duck, you’re learning about science, art, and history. It’s a way to tell stories and celebrate nature. It’s fun, creative, and helps you feel like part of the Down East communities.